
Core Mathematics

A Practical Guide on Mathematics for Physics Learners

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These are lecture notes for first-year university students in physics or physical science. They cover the mathematical tools you need most: calculus, logic, complex numbers, and vectors, with introductions to vector calculus, differential equations, and statistical analysis. Exercises are central to these notes. Practice each topic repeatedly until you can work through problems quickly and accurately.

Preface

Physics is an activity to describe the world, but how? At present, mathematics (+ *broken* English) is the only language we can use. So, unfortunately, we need to learn mathematics! (and English...🙄) But, in some sense, we are fortunate because we have a language to describe the world. In fact, math and physics have developed together. We understand physics better if we study mathematics well!

When you do DIY, you need to use the tools properly, smoothly, and accurately. It is the same here; when we use math as a tool, it must be **logical**, **quick**, and **accurate**. To be logical, you must think each problem carefully; otherwise your discussion might be incomplete and you can't convince others. To be quick and accurate, you must "*drill*" repeatedly, as if top NBA players do shooting practice almost everyday. You should reach the point where basic calculations feel automatic.

This is not a math textbook. **This is rather** a math "drill" book. Rigorous proofs are mostly omitted, but drill problems are the core of this document, through which students are expected to achieve better conceptual understanding.

Target of this document

This document is primarily for first-year undergraduate students in their second semester, who

- completed basic calculus (differentiation and integration),
- are going to major in physics or physical science, and
- do not hesitate to do repetitive practice to achieve better conceptual understanding.

How to use this document

1. Buy a **A4-sized paper notebook**.

Digital notebooks on tablets are not suitable (or less effective) for this document.

2. Read the text with solving Quizzes.

You can solve "Quizzes" without writing down the solution process.

3. Solve Drill Problems to nourish fluency.

Mind the fluency ($\neq$ speed) and accuracy. Write down the solution process clearly.

4. Solve other problems to have better conceptual understanding (& writing skills).

Think carefully and write down the solution process clearly as an **English text**, taking care of logical completeness.

5. Optionally, you are encouraged to prepare a reference book, so that you can consult it when you want to know more. (Sho supposes [Boas] listed below is the best option.)



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Visit <https://github.com/misho104/LecturePublic> for further information, updates, and to report issues.

References

This document is written under the influence of the following references.

- [The Math Book by Hal Tasaki](#) (数学：物理を学び楽しむために, in Japanese)

A free book with full description, but unfortunately in Japanese. Topic selections and the depth of descriptions are based on this reference.

- [First-Year Math Practice](#) (in Japanese)

This document is grounded in a “learn steadily” approach (“じっくり” in Japanese), which originates from Prof. Gocho and Prof. Kiyono, who were instructors of Sho in his freshman. Problems and rigorous math descriptions are taken from their works.

- **[Boas]** Mary L. Boas, *Mathematical Methods in the Physical Sciences*, 3rd ed., Wiley, 2006.

- **[AWH]** George B. Arfken, Hans J. Weber, and Frank E. Harris, *Mathematical Methods for Physicists*, 7th ed., Academic Press, 2023.

These two books are widely used in physics departments around the world. [Boas] seems more friendly to beginners, while [AWH] seems more detailed and complete. Sho recommends you to study [Boas] *in parallel with* this document, using it as a reference, and to consult [AWH] when you want more details or more exercises.

Lecture Plan

The content is designed for 150-minute $\times$ 14-week lectures, as it is originally for a lecture *Mathematics for Fundamental Physics* (基礎物理数学) in National Sun Yat-sen University (國立中山大學).

1. Derivative
2. Units. Significant Digits.
3. Logic. Theorems. a^x and $\log_a x$.
4. Logic. Theorems. a^x and $\log_a x$.
5. Vectors are arrows.
6. $a \cdot b$ and $a \times b$
7. Matrices (rotation, reflection, scaling)
8. Complex numbers (polar form, Euler's formula, multi-valuedness)
9. Complex vectors, Hermitian inner product, bra-ket notation
10. Vector calculus (grad, div, rot; example of point charge)
11. ODE basics
12. ODE basics
13. Probability and error analysis
14. Probability and error analysis

♣TODO♣a bit on (abstract) vector space to prep for QM?

Symbols

Mathematical Notations

Chapter 1

$\mathbb{N}$	natural numbers
$\mathbb{N}_0$	natural numbers (0, 1, 2, ...)
$\mathbb{N}^+$	natural numbers (1, 2, ...)
$\mathbb{R}$	real numbers
$\mathbb{Q}$	rational numbers
$\mathbb{C}$	complex numbers

Greek symbols

A α alpha	H η eta	N ν nu	T τ tau
B β beta	Θ θ theta	Ξ ξ xi	Y υ upsilon
Γ γ gamma	I ι iota	O $\omicron$ omicron	Φ $\varphi(\phi)$ phi
Δ δ delta	K κ kappa	Π π pi	X χ chi
E ε epsilon	Λ λ lambda	P ρ rho	Ψ ψ psi
Z ζ zeta	M μ mu	Σ σ sigma	Ω ω omega

Gray-outed ones are almost never used, but others are almost always used. You need to write them so that **others can distinguish each from others**, but Sho thinks Japanese- or Chinese-speakers are OK with it, as we everyday read and write 日 vs 日 vs 白 or 土 vs 土 vs 工 properly!

Quiz

★1. Read out the following words.

- | | | |
|---|----------------------------------|---|
| (1) α -particle | (2) β -decay | (3) Γ -function |
| (4) ε - δ definition | (5) angle θ and φ | (6) μ - and τ -leptons |
| (7) $\psi(x)$ and $\varphi(x)$ | (8) ζ and ξ | (9) metric $\eta_{\mu\nu}$ |
| (10) X-ray and γ -ray | (11) Ω -baryon | (12) $\varepsilon_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}$ -tensor |

Problems

👉0.1. Write the following letters so that people can distinguish each from others.

- | | | | |
|------------------|------------------------------------|---------------|-------------------------|
| (1) a, α | (2) b, β | (3) c, C | (4) e, E, ε |
| (5) ζ, ξ | (6) $\Theta, \theta, Q, \sigma, 6$ | (7) $g, q, 9$ | (8) $i, l, 1, I$ |

(9) k, K, κ	(10) m, μ	(11) p, ρ	(12) s, S
(13) t, τ, T	(14) u, v, ν	(15) w, W, ω	(16) x, X, χ

SI Units

Historically, different civilizations used different units. Today, science and engineering worldwide use the **SI units** (Système International d'Unités)—the single international standard. It is built from seven **SI base units**:

Table 1: SI base units and their symbols for dimension [1]. Recall that units are case-sensitive.

quantity	symbol and name	symbol for dimension
time	s (second)	T
length	m (meter)	L
mass	kg (kilogram)	M
electric current	A (ampere)	I
temperature	K (kelvin)	Θ
amount of substance	mol (mole)	N
luminous intensity	cd (candela)	J

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Bibliography

- [1] Bureau International des Poids et Mesures, “The International System of Units (SI),” BIPM. [Online]. Available: <https://doi.org/10.59161/AUEZ1291>

Chapter 1

Derivative (Review)

1.1 The first step

Remark: This document is designed for first-year students in their *second semester*, who **have already studied derivatives** in their first-semester “calculus” course. If you are not yet confident with derivatives, please study [the Derivative Boot Camp](#) first^{#1}.

Birds sing, fish swim, flowers bloom, stars twinkle, and university students calculate derivatives. Let us begin with basic **derivatives**. Try the next quiz—and note how long it takes.

Quiz

★1. Calculate the first derivatives of the following functions.

- | | | | |
|------------------|--------------------------|------------------|---------------------|
| (1) $(x + 1)^3$ | (2) $\tan x$ | (3) $2 \cos^2 x$ | (4) $2 \cos x^2$ |
| (5) $x^3 \cos x$ | (6) $\frac{3 \sin x}{x}$ | (7) $x^{3/2}$ | (8) $\sqrt{\sin x}$ |

If you finished within two minutes—Wonderful! Most students take 3–4 minutes. If you took more than four minutes, do not worry: you can do the calculations, and a little more practice will help. Try some problems in [the Derivative Boot Camp](#)

Did you make calculation mistakes and get wrong answers? That is a serious issue—just as serious as forgetting how to do the calculations at all. You will perform similar calculations more than 100 times in university, so you need to be both fast and accurate.



At university, students often underestimate the importance of basic calculations. In physics, simple calculations appear constantly, so your speed and accuracy directly affect how well you follow lectures, how efficiently you study, and ultimately your grade. Both can be improved with practice.

This course will help you strengthen these basic calculations—some of which you already know from high school—while also introducing new topics that are essential for physics. You will solve many problems and drills, just as a beginner athlete repeats the same move hundreds of times to master it.

^{#1} Visit <https://misho104.github.io/LecturePublic> and find gp1_boot1_deriv_true.pdf.

1.2 Typical Pitfalls

1.2.1 Notations

There are several equivalent ways to write the derivative of $f(x)$:

$$f'(x) = \frac{df}{dx}(x) = \frac{df(x)}{dx} = \frac{d}{dx}f(x) \quad [\text{All means the same thing}]. \quad (1.1)$$

Similarly, the value of $f'(x)$ at a specific point $x = 3$ can be written as

$$f'(3) = f'(x)\big|_{x=3} = \frac{df}{dx}\bigg|_{x=3} = \frac{df}{dx}(3) = \frac{d}{dx}f(3), \quad (1.2)$$

and they are all equivalent. For example, if $f(x) = 3x^2 + 6$, then $f'(x) = 6x$ and $f'(3) = 18$.

The real pitfalls come next. Students often get confused when a **constant** a appears. If a is declared as a constant, we can define a function such as $g(x) = ax^2 + 2a$, for which

$$g'(x) = 2ax. \quad (1.3)$$

We can evaluate $g'(x)$ at $x = a$. The result is $g'(a) = 2a^2$, written as

$$g'(a) = g'(x)\big|_{x=a} = \frac{dg}{dx}(a) = \frac{d}{dx}g(a) = 2a^2. \quad (1.4)$$

Be careful: the notation $\frac{d}{dx}g(a)$ does **not** mean $\frac{d}{dx}[g(a)] = \frac{d}{dx}(a^3 + 2a) = 0$.

Fail safe note: If you can't see Eq. (1.3), try setting $a = 3$. Then, $g(x) = f(x)$, and $g'(x)$ should equal $f'(x)$.

There is more bad news. *Physicists are often lazy*, and we frequently omit the argument (x) . For example, if $f(x) = 3x^2$ and $F(t) = t^2 + at + 1$, and if a is declared as a constant,

$$\begin{aligned} f' &= \frac{d}{dx}f = 6x, & f'(a) &= \frac{d}{dx}f(a) = 6a, \\ F' &= \frac{d}{dt}F = 2t + a, & F'(a) &= \frac{d}{dt}F(a) = 3a. \end{aligned} \quad (1.5)$$

So when you see a function written as f , you must identify its variable by reading the context. For example, we sometimes replace the variables. Assume $f(x) = 3x^2$. If t is another **variable** (= not a constant), we can understand $3t^2$ is the same function $f(t)$. So we may write $f(t) = 3t^2$, whose derivative is $f'(t) = df/dt = 6t$.

Advanced note: We usually write “Let k be a constant” to declare k as a constant. You need to do so, too.

Higher-order derivatives is written as

$$\frac{d}{dx}\left(\frac{df}{dx}\right) = \frac{d^2f}{dx^2} = f''(x) = f^{(2)}(x), \quad \frac{d}{dx}\left(\frac{d}{dx}\left(\frac{df}{dx}\right)\right) = \frac{d^3f}{dx^3} = f'''(x) = f^{(3)}(x), \quad (1.6)$$

etc. Please be careful on the position of “2” and “3”.

Quiz

★2. Let a and b be constants. If $f(x) = 3x^2$, $g(t) = at^2 + b$, $F(x) = a + 3$, and $G(t) = a \cos(t) + x \sin(t)$, what are the following expressions?

- | | | | |
|----------------------|-------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|
| (1) $f'(x)$ | (2) $f'(0)$ | (3) $f'(a)$ | (4) $f'(-a)$ |
| (5) $g'(t)$ | (6) $g'(0)$ | (7) $g'(b)$ | (8) $g'(x)$ |
| (9) $F'(a)$ | (10) $G'(t)$ | (11) $G'(0)$ | (12) $G'(a)$ |
| (13) $\frac{df}{dx}$ | (14) $\frac{df}{dx}(0)$ | (15) $\frac{dg}{dt}$ | (16) $\frac{dg(x)}{dx}$ |

1.2.2 Radian and trigonometric functions

At university, angles are almost always measured in **radians**:

$$360 \text{ degree (or: } 360^\circ) = 2\pi \text{ radian (or: } 2\pi \text{ rad)} \quad (1.7)$$

Furthermore, we usually omit “radian” (because we are lazy!) Now,

$$\text{a right angle is } \pi/2. \quad \text{The sum of the interior angles of a triangle is } \pi. \quad (1.8)$$

Quiz

★3. Express the following angles in radians, and radians in angles.

- | | | | | |
|-----------------|----------------|----------------|---------------|-----------------|
| (1) 180° | (2) 45° | (3) 60° | (4) 90 | (5) -30° |
| (6) 1° | (7) 1 | (8) -0.3 | (9) x° | (10) x |

Why do insist on radians? The answer comes from the derivative formula

$$\frac{d}{dx} \sin x = \cos x. \quad (1.9)$$

Because we have chosen radians as the standard, $(\sin x)'$ becomes this simple.

Advanced note: The simpleness of Eq. (1.9) originates in the fact $\sin(0.01 \text{ rad}) \approx 0.01$. If we used degrees, we would have $\sin(0.01^\circ) \approx 0.01 \times 0.017453$ and everything is messed up with this number 0.017453.

There are a few remarks in the notation of **trigonometric functions**:

$$\begin{aligned} \sin^2 x &\neq \sin x^2. & \text{Namely, } (\sin x)^2 = \sin^2 x &\neq \sin x^2 = \sin(x^2). \\ \tan^{-1} x &\neq \frac{1}{\tan x}. & \text{Namely, } \tan^{-1} x = \arctan x &\neq (\tan x)^{-1} = \frac{1}{\tan x} = \cot x. \end{aligned} \quad (1.10)$$

The following are not incorrect but confusing. *We should avoid ambiguity*, so please don't use them.

$$\sin^{-2} x, \quad \sin^{1/2} x, \quad \sin(x)^2, \quad \sin(x+1)^2, \dots$$

Sho thinks we should only use $\sin^k x$ for $k = 2, 3, 4, \dots$, and use $\arcsin x$ instead of $\sin^{-1} x$.

1.2.3 Several interpretations of derivatives

When you, physics learners, discuss $f'(t)$, you should have the following three interpretations:

- Regarding t as the time, $f'(t)$ is the **rate of change** of $f(t)$ per unit time. If $f'(t) > 0$, the function f is increasing at the time t , while $f'(t) < 0$ means it is decreasing.
- Consider a graph of $f(t)$. Then, $f'(t)$ is the slope of the **tangent line** to the graph at the point t .
- Mathematically, $f'(t)$ is defined by (Check that they are equivalent.)

$$f'(t) := \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(t + \Delta t) - f(t)}{\Delta t} = \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(t + h) - f(t - h)}{2h} = \lim_{s \rightarrow t} \frac{f(s) - f(t)}{s - t}. \quad (1.11)$$

If you are unsure of them, please consult your first-year Calculus textbooks for further information.

1.3 Taylor expansion

Reviewing the previous equation for a function $f(x)$, we have

$$f'(x) := \lim_{\Delta x \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(x + \Delta x) - f(x)}{\Delta x}, \quad f'(a) := \lim_{\delta \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(a + \delta) - f(a)}{\delta}. \quad (1.12)$$

Advanced note: These two have a bit different sense: the first one defines a new function $f'(x)$, while the second one defines a number that is eventually equal to $f'(x)|_{x=a}$. Anyway, we don't care the difference.

We can understand the second equation as

$$\text{If } \delta \approx 0, \quad f'(a) \approx \frac{f(a + \delta) - f(a)}{\delta}, \quad \text{i.e.,} \quad f(a + \delta) \approx f(a) + \delta f'(a). \quad (1.13)$$

These equations will be helpful if you want to know **what is $f(x)$ around the point $x = a$?**

Example 1.1

Find the approximate value of the following expressions:

(1) $\sqrt{1.002}$

(2) $(1.002)^{10}$

(3) $\sqrt{4.004}$

Solution

(1) Apply Eq. (1.13) for $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$, $a = 1$, and $\delta = 0.002$. Then,

$$f'(x) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}, \quad f'(a) = f'(1) = \frac{1}{2}, \quad f'(a) \approx f(a) + \delta f'(a) = \sqrt{1} + \frac{\delta}{2} = \underline{1.001}.$$

(2) Doing the same thing for $g(x) = x^{10}$, we have

$$g'(x) = 10x^9, \quad g'(a) = g'(1) = 10, \quad g'(a) \approx g(a) + \delta g'(a) = 1^{10} + 10\delta = \underline{1.02}.$$

(3) Doing the same thing for $h(x) = \sqrt{x}$, $a = 4$, and $\delta = 0.004$, we have

$$h'(4) = \frac{1}{4}, \quad h'(4.004) \approx h(4) + 0.004 \times \frac{1}{4} = \underline{2.001}.$$

This technique, and Eq. (1.13), is a special case of the more general **Taylor's theorem**:

♣TODO♣postpone the discussion below to a later chapter

Theorem 1.2 (Taylor's theorem)

If a function $f(x)$ is sufficiently smooth, we can express it as

$$f(x) = \sum_{k=0}^N \frac{(x-a)^k}{k!} f^{(k)}(a) + [\text{dangerous part}]. \quad (1.14)$$

and we can ignore the dangerous part if $x \approx a$. So, if we replace x by $a + \varepsilon$ and $\varepsilon \approx 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} f(a + \varepsilon) &= \sum_{k=0}^N \frac{\varepsilon^k}{k!} f^{(k)}(a) + [\text{dangerous part}] \\ &\approx f(a) + \varepsilon f'(a) + \frac{\varepsilon^2}{2} f''(a) + \frac{\varepsilon^3}{6} f'''(a) + \dots \end{aligned} \quad (1.15)$$

Problems

★1.1. Find the approximate value of the following expressions:

- | | | |
|-------------------|--------------------|-------------------|
| (1) $(1.002)^5$ | (2) $\sin(0.001)$ | (3) $\cos(0.001)$ |
| (4) $\tan(0.001)$ | (5) $\sqrt{4.004}$ | |

***1.2. Find the approximate value of the following expressions:

- | | | |
|---------------------|--------------------|-----------------------|
| (1) $\sin(3.14)$ | (2) $\cos(1.57)$ | (3) $\sqrt[3]{1.001}$ |
| (4) $(1.002)^{0.9}$ | (5) $1/(10.004)^3$ | (6) $\sqrt{10001}$ |

Fail safe note: If you are not confident with the meaning of $\sqrt[3]{1.001}$, $(1.001)^{-0.9}$, etc., please go to
♣TODO♣a chapter...

**1.3. Write down the definition of the second derivative $f''(x)$. Repeat the discussion of Eq. (1.13) to find the expansion $f'(a + \varepsilon) \approx f'(a) + \varepsilon f''(a) + (\varepsilon^2/2) f'''(a)$.

♣TODO♣more problems

Chapter 2

Units and Significant figures

A **physical quantity** is usually made of a number, a unit, and an **uncertainty (error)**. For example,

	unit	central value	absolute uncertainty	relative uncertainty
$10 \text{ m} \pm 1 \text{ cm}$	m (meter)	10 m	1 cm = 0.01 m	0.001 (or 0.1%)
$1.6 \text{ A} \pm 0.04 \text{ A}$	A (ampere)	1.6 A	0.04 A	0.025 (or 2.5%)
$(5 \pm 1) \times 10^{-3} \text{ C}$	C (coulomb)	0.005 C	0.001 C	0.2 (or 20%)
$(50 \pm 1) \text{ m/s}$	m/s	50 m/s	1 m/s	0.02 (or 2%)

Measurements are always with uncertainty. Proper Handling of the uncertainty is a fundamental skill. Uncertainty can often be more important than the central value.

Remark: Upper- and lowercase letters are distinguished. “M” **does not** mean “meter”. The unit “A” is “ampere”, not “Ampere”. The unit “coulomb” is “C”, not “c”.

Quiz

★1. For each of the following values, find its unit, central value, absolute uncertainty, and relative uncertainty.

(1) $50 \text{ kg} \pm 500 \text{ g}$

(2) $(0.05 \pm 0.001) \text{ A}$

(3) $(1.6 \pm 0.001) \times 10^{-19} \text{ C}$

(4) $72 \text{ km/h} \pm 1 \text{ m/s}$

★2. The next passage has six (6) errors in the use of uppercase and lowercase letters. Find them out.

In the SI system, temperature is expressed in k (kelvin), a unit named after Lord Kelvin. The unit of force is N (newton), named after the british scientist Isaac newton. The units A (Ampere) and c (coulomb) are named after French scientists. In contrast, Kg (kilogram) is not named after a person, but comes from Greek.

As an undergraduate student, you need to follow the following rules:

1. Numbers are always with units, even in calculations.
2. Include units in a symbol.
3. For physical quantities, use decimals (e.g., 1.6 A). Do not use fractions like $(8/5) \text{ A}$.
4. Use significant figures to express the measurement precision.

Significant figures are a simple way to express the uncertainty. We discuss it in this chapter, while Chapter ♣**TODD**♣**chapter** has further discussion on uncertainty and error analysis.

2.1 Units

When we educate kids, we write “my height is $\square$ cm”, or “my height is h cm”, where $h = 172$ is just a number. This is inconvenient, because we want to convert the units freely and write equations such as $1.72 \text{ m} = 172 \text{ cm} = 0.00172 \text{ km}$. So,

we always include units in symbols: $h = 172 \text{ cm}$

and then

we can write: $h = 172 \text{ cm} = 1.72 \text{ m} = 0.00172 \text{ km} = 1.82 \times 10^{-16} \text{ light-year}$.

Similarly, if $m = 110 \text{ g}$ and $g = 9.8 \text{ m/s}^2$,

we may write: $w = mg = 110 \text{ g} \times 9.8 \text{ m/s}^2 = 1.1 \text{ kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2$

but not: $w = mg = 0.11 \times 9.8 = 1.1 \text{ kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2$;

the second equation is incorrect because m is not equal to 0.11. It is equal to 0.11 kg or 110 g.

Remark: Usually physicists use upright fonts for units and *italic fonts* for quantities. For example, m , T , and C are quantity symbols (describing mass, temperature, etc.), while m, T, and C are units (meter, tesla, and coulomb, respectively).

Every physical concept has its own unit. For example, speed has m/s, acceleration has m/s^2 , and energy has $\text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2 = \text{N} \cdot \text{m} = \text{J}$. The table below lists the quantities you have learned. Notice that angle (rad) has no dimension. It is called a **dimensionless** quantity.

concept	dimension	typical unit
speed	L T^{-1}	m/s
acceleration	L T^{-2}	m/s^2
linear momentum	M L T^{-1}	$\text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}$
force	M L T^{-2}	$\text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2$ (= N)
energy / work	$\text{M L}^2 \text{T}^{-2}$	$\text{kg} \cdot \text{m}^2/\text{s}^2$ (= J)
frequency	T^{-1}	1/s (= Hz)
angle	1 (dimensionless)	rad

Advanced note: To understand why angle has no dimension, you may consider the definition of the radian: it is defined as the ratio of the arc length to the radius, so the units cancel (meter / meter = 1).

Here,

please do not write: $\text{the force is } \text{kg} \cdot \text{m}^2/\text{s}^2, \text{ which is also called newton (N)}$.

because *we cannot mix units and concepts*. A correct (and easy) way is to use English words:

the unit of the force is $\text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2$ or the force has the unit $\text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2$.

Similarly, the following statement is incorrect because it mixes concepts and units:

$$\text{Since } m = \text{kg and } g = \text{m/s}^2, mg = \text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2 = \text{N}.$$

Instead, you need to write

$$\text{Since } m \text{ has a unit of kg and } g \text{ has a unit of m/s}^2, mg \text{ has a unit of kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2 = \text{N}.$$

Notice the last equation: units can be equal to other units, so we may write

$$\text{N} = \text{J/m} = \text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2, \quad \text{m} = \text{J/N}, \quad \text{s} = \sqrt{\text{kg} \cdot \text{m/N}}.$$

These are scientifically correct equations.

Remark: We sometimes use informal notations, such as $[F] = \text{N}$ or $F \rightsquigarrow \text{N}$ to express “the unit of F is N (newton)”. Still, using an equal symbol ($=$) is **not allowed**. Namely, $F = \text{N}$ is always incorrect.

Advanced note: In very formal situations, we use **symbols for dimensions** (see Table 1 on page 5):

Since $\dim(m) = \text{M}$ and $\dim(g) = \text{L T}^{-2}$, $\dim(mg) = \text{M L T}^{-2}$,
with the operator “dim” [1]. However, it seems too complicated for educational purpose.

Quiz

★3. Using English, explain what unit the following quantities have.

(1) speed (2) velocity (3) force (4) energy (5) power

★4. Express the following units only with SI base units, e.g., $\text{N} = \text{kg} \cdot \text{m/s}^2$.

(1) W (watt) (2) Pa (pascal) (3) J (joule) (4) C (coulomb)

**5. Use “dim” notation to express the dimensions of the following quantities. For example, if v is speed, then $\dim(v) = \text{L T}^{-1}$.

(1) speed v	(2) force F
(3) angular momentum L	(4) electric charge Q
(5) resistance R	(6) specific heat capacity c
(7) Planck constant h	(8) fine-structure constant α

**6. Find a few more examples of dimensionless quantities in physics.

2.2 Significant figures

In researches, we need to treat uncertainties in the method given in ♣TODO♣chap. However, most of lectures use **significant figures** to express the accuracy of a value, so that students becomes familiar with the concept of uncertainties. For example,

3.14	means the last digit “4” is uncertain. It can be 3.16, 3.15, 3.11, 3.10,
3.141	means “3.14” is for sure but it can be 3.143, 3.142, 3.140, 3.139,
3.1415	might be 3.1416, 3.14153, etc., but the author is sure it cannot be 3.145 or 3.135.

You have seen trailing zeros in your textbook. They are important because

1.0000	means the last digit “0” is uncertain so it may be 1.0002, 1.0001, 0.9998,
1.00	can be 1.03 or 0.99, but the author is sure it cannot be 1.2 or 0.8.

This notation is often combined with **scientific notation**:

0.000123	is OK but we prefer	1.23×10^{-4} .	Both mean the value can be 1.22×10^{-4} etc.
0.00100	is OK but we prefer	1.00×10^{-3} .	
29979	is OK but we prefer	2.9979×10^4 .	

We need to *avoid ambiguous notations*. Namely,

2040	is ambiguous and not nice. We are not sure the author means 2.04×10^3 or 2.040×10^3 .
120	is not nice. We are not sure the author means It may mean 1.20×10^2 or 1.2×10^2 .
42000	is not nice because it has four ways to interpret the author’s intention.

Quiz

★7. What are the four interpretations of 42000? Write them in scientific notation.

★8. (1) Some of the following numbers are ambiguous. Point them out.
(2) Write the other (not ambiguous) numbers in scientific notation.

152 340 1000 9999 43210 0.0300 0.00213 31.0 31.00 31

★9. The expressions 0.123, 1.23, and 123 are numbers with **three significant figures**. Similarly, 1234 and 1.234×10^{-3} are numbers with **four significant figures**. How about the following expressions?

- | | | | |
|------------|--------------|--------------------------|----------------------------|
| (1) 3.14 | (2) 0.11 | (3) 1.1×10^{-2} | (4) 1.1×10 |
| (5) 1.0008 | (6) 1.0020 | (7) 1.0000 | (8) 4.00×10^{-10} |
| (9) 0.0008 | (10) 0.00080 | (11) 12345 | (12) 67890 |

Remark: On computers, we often use $2.99\text{e}8$ (or $2.99\text{E}8$) to mean 2.99×10^8 , or $1.610\text{e}-12$ (or $1.610\text{E}-12$) to mean 1.610×10^{-12} . However, we **should not** use them in hand-writing.

We use **rounding-to-the-nearest** (四捨五入) when necessary. For example, if you need to convert to three significant figures, it will be

$$1.234 \rightarrow 1.23, \quad 1.235 \rightarrow 1.24, \quad 31.98 \rightarrow 32.0, \quad 1234 \rightarrow 1.23 \times 10^3, \quad \text{and so on.}$$

Quiz

★10. Round the following numbers to three significant figures.

(1) 41.11

(2) 98.76

(3) 100.12

(4) 15.449

(5) 2.2360

(6) 0.0123456

(7) 9876

(8) 9.999×10^4

2.3 Calculation with Significant figures

Now we are to calculate these numbers with significant figures, such as $1.23 + 4.56$ or $1.23/4.56$, but how? The professional methods are given in ♣TODO♣chap. Here we discuss a simple method for

- addition ($x + y$) and subtraction ($x - y$)
- multiplication ($x \times y$) and division ($x \div y$ or x/y)

Treatments for $\sqrt{x}$, e^x or $\sin(x)$ need the professional method given in ♣TODO♣chap.

Multiplication and Division

If x has m significant figures and y has n significant figures, then $x \times m$ or $x \div y$ should be rounded to have $\min(m, n)$ significant figures.

Example 2.3

Calculate the following expressions, using calculators.

(1) 8.912×2.4

(2) $5.0 \div 3.14$

(3) 2.01×49.8

(4) 1.210^3

Solution

Here we use a shorthand notation “3-SF” to mean “three significant figures”.

(1) Since 8.912 has 4-SF and 2.4 has 2-SF, we round the result to (the smaller) 2-SF:

$$8.912 \times 2.4 = 21.3888 \rightarrow \underline{21}.$$

(2) Since 5.0 has 2-SF and 3.14 has 3-SF, we round the result to 2-SF:

$$5.0 \div 3.14 = 1.592... \rightarrow \underline{1.6}.$$

(3) Both 2.01 and 49.8 have 3-SF, so we keep 3-SF, but don't forget to avoid ambiguity!

$$2.01 \times 49.8 = 100.098 \rightarrow 100 \rightarrow \underline{1.00 \times 10^2}.$$

(4) $1.210^3 = 1.210 \times 1.210 \times 1.210$, so we round the result to 4-SF:

$$1.210^3 = 1.771561 \rightarrow \underline{1.772}.$$

This treatment is justified if you recall You may understand this

The significant-figure rules for multiplication and division are a consequence of the relative-uncertainty rule. The relative uncertainty of a product or quotient is dominated by the factor with the largest relative uncertainty, which is the least precise factor. Therefore, we round the result to have the same number of significant figures as the least precise factor. The significant-figure rules for calculations are a consequence of uncertainty propagation. After computing a result, round it so that it does not claim more precision than the data support.

- **Multiplication and division:** keep the same number of significant figures as the least precise factor. (This reflects the relative-uncertainty rule: the least precise factor dominates the relative uncertainty of the result.)
- **Addition and subtraction:** round to the least number of *decimal places* among all terms. (This reflects the absolute-uncertainty rule: the term with the largest absolute uncertainty dominates.)

For example:

$$3.3 \times 1.11 = 3.663 \rightarrow 3.7 \quad (\text{two s.f.}), \quad (2.1)$$

$$22.2 + 3.51 = 25.71 \rightarrow 25.7 \quad (\text{one decimal place}). \quad (2.2)$$

Remark: These are the beginner rules. Professional scientists and engineers use more nuanced conventions that depend on their field. You will learn those from your supervisors in the future.